Those who understand the dynamics of the Sangh Parivar believe the tussle between the leadership of the two outfits was nothing but a "lover's tiff". Sources in the Sangh also vouch for the bond between PM Modi and sarsanghchalak Bhagwat, saying it is one of shared ideology and deep mutual respect. Their commitment towards this is reflected in the work their respective offices have done in the past decade.

Long Road to Nagpur

Before reaching Nagpur, PM Modi had ensured that the party and his government had made some course corrections to appease the Sangh leadership. Sangh leaders had been uncomfortable for some time now with the "large-scale import" of politicians from other parties, some of them with a known anti-RSS past. Unlike the Atal Bihari Vajpayee era, when the Sangh affiliates had frequent fights with the government, Modi has ensured that regular consultations and *samanvay* (coordination) meetings happened with them.

But political expediency being the byword, there had been little discussion before importing some of the aforementioned leaders and giving them key assignments. Now, as part of the course correction, regular consultations are taking place with local Sangh units for the ongoing organisational elections in the state, which, in turn, will build the electoral college to find the next national party president (Nadda's term is over and he's on an extension). The RSS is also in on the discussions for the appointments of governors and other political offices.

The organisation's demand for the distribution of more powers to its men at the central level has also been accepted. This included more work allocation to cabinet ministers such as Rajnath Singh, Manohar Lal Khattar and Shivraj Singh Chouhan. So, Khattar now leads the ministerial group recommending the appointments of independent directors on PSU boards, while Chouhan oversees the implementation of many schemes the prime minister has announced, along with crucial infrastructure projects.



IN MEMORY PM Modi pays tribute to RSS founder K.B. Hedgewar at Smruti Mandir in Nagpur, Mar. 30

State of Play

Meanwhile, the party is also going through a period of transition. A new BJP national president will be elected soon, a rejigging of the national team and several state units is under way, a cabinet reshuffle is a real possibility, and plans for the 'new territories' are also being reworked. Sources say the party is also 'realigning its formations' for the forthcoming assembly polls in Bihar, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Kerala. All four are difficult states for the BJP, and will require all the support the Sangh and its affiliates can offer.

In Kerala, for instance, the Lok Sabha polls showed that the NDA vote share had increased to 19.2 per cent; actor Suresh Gopi also won the Thrissur seat, a first for the party. Now, a big gamble has been taken with the elevation of businessman-turned-politician Rajeev Chandrasekhar—who